KRAKÓW, POLAND

National Museum in Kraków: Masterpieces

From Cecilia Gallerani's turned head to Matejko's crowds, bodies organise private and public meaning.



An extended hand may hold an animal, announce a prophecy, offer a dangerous drink or perform a small act of care. The gesture itself is only the beginning. Its meaning depends on the bodies around it, the attention it receives and the space in which it occurs. This selection makes those relationships particularly visible, moving between concentrated portraits and densely populated historical scenes.

Wyspiański provides another scale of comparison: a child's resting arms and a sweeping window design ask very different things of a human figure. Read the works across those differences. A recognisable public subject does not make every expression self-explanatory, and a private sitter need not supply a complete personal story.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-museum-krakow

The selection · 20

1. Lady with an Ermine
   Leonardo da Vinci · 1489-1490
2. Girl with Chrysanthemums
   Olga Boznańska · 1894
3. Portrait of Paul Nauen
   Olga Boznańska · 1893
4. Frenzy
   Władysław Podkowiński · 1894
5. Four-in-Hand
   Józef Chełmoński · 1881
6. The Storm
   Józef Chełmoński · 1896
7. Wernyhora
   Jan Matejko · 1884
8. Kościuszko at Racławice
   Jan Matejko · 1888
9. Polonia 1863
   Jan Matejko · 1864
10. The Poisoning of Queen Bona
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11. Apollo: Copernicus's Solar System
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12. Motherhood
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16. God the Father: Replica of a Window Design
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17. Self-Portrait with a Palette
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    Jacek Malczewski · 1914
19. The Death of Ellenai
    Jacek Malczewski · 1883
20. The Red Parasol
    Józef Mehoffer · 1917

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Lady with an Ermine

Leonardo da Vinci

1489-1490 · National Museum in Kraków



Leonardo da Vinci. The Lady with an Ermine (Cecilia Gallerani). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Cecilia Gallerani and the ermine share a direction of attention without sharing an identical pose. Her long hand follows the animal's back, physically joining their separate movements. Leonardo makes an unseen point outside the frame relevant to the portrait. The sitter's turn introduces an encounter that the picture suggests but does not complete for the viewer.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Girl with Chrysanthemums

Olga Boznańska

1894 · National Museum in Kraków



Olga Boznańska. Girl with Chrysanthemums. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The white flowers interrupt a closely related range of greys, helping the clasped hands register beneath the girl's direct, dark-eyed look. Boznańska leaves the setting spare, so small distinctions carry unusual weight. The portrait's intensity does not need an invented explanation of the child's feelings. It arises from a sustained meeting with a face given little surrounding distraction.

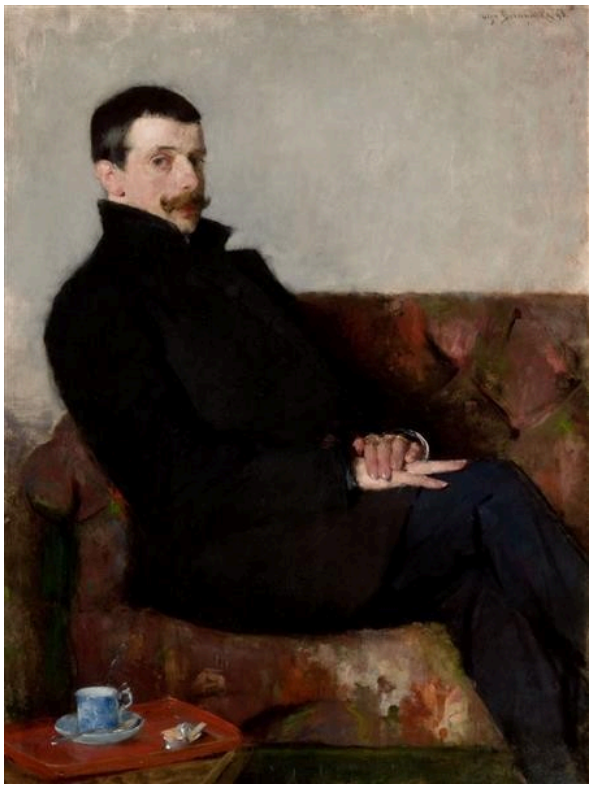
Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Portrait of Paul Nauen

Olga Boznańska

1893 · National Museum in Kraków



Olga Boznańska. Portrait of Paul Nauen. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The sitter's sideways body and answering turn of the head suggest a pause within an occupied room. The nearby cup contributes to that sense of an interrupted visit, while the dense black clothing isolates face and hands. Boznańska makes a formal likeness through a comparatively informal arrangement. The pose supplies an occasion without requiring a detailed anecdote.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Frenzy

Władysław Podkowiński

1894 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Władysław Podkowiński; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The woman's grip joins her pale body to the horse's rearing darkness. Podkowiński makes the pair inseparable yet precarious: the force carrying one body upward endangers the balance of the other. The indistinct ground provides little reassurance. The title's excess becomes a physical arrangement of attachment and instability rather than a feeling merely announced by a face.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-b-887

05 / 20

Four-in-Hand

Józef Chełmoński

1881 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Józef Chełmoński. Four-in-Hand. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jozef-chelmonski/four-in-hand-1881 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The horses occupy the breadth of the composition as they advance towards the near ground. Chełmoński makes the team's spread difficult to take in as one compact object; legs and bodies divide its forward energy. The large horizontal canvas intensifies that approach. This Kraków work should be kept distinct from the smaller related carriage scene in the Warsaw collection.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Storm

Józef Chełmoński

1896 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Józef Chełmoński; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

Bent bodies and hurried movement make the weather consequential before the lightning is noticed. Clothing and carried bundles pull against the figures' progress, giving the storm a series of practical effects. Chełmoński keeps the field connected to work and exposure. The sky's drama is measured through what it requires people on the ground to do.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-a-237

07 / 20

Wernyhora

Jan Matejko

1884 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Jan Matejko; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The raised hand marks a source of prophetic authority, but the listeners do not all answer it in the same way. Their different faces and directions of attention make the utterance spread unevenly through the gathering. Matejko gives the central gesture its force through reception. The surrounding people are participants in its meaning, not merely a decorative audience.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-a-433

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Kościuszko at Racławice

Jan Matejko

1888 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Jan Matejko; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

Banners, riders and raised gestures organise a public gathering after battle, while wounded bodies retain another account of the event in the foreground. Matejko makes ceremony share the landscape with its cost. The broad historical scene cannot be understood through the mounted central figure alone. Smaller participants complicate the victory that the main gathering presents.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-a-151

09 / 20

Polonia 1863

Jan Matejko

1864 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Jan Matejko; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The personification of Poland occupies a compressed interior among soldiers and restrained figures. An extended pale arm makes coercion locally visible, converting a political condition into contact between bodies. Matejko does not leave the allegory safely abstract. The closeness of the participants makes power operate within reach of the vulnerable figure rather than at a distant historical scale.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK XII-453

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The Poisoning of Queen Bona

Jan Matejko

1859 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Jan Matejko; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The vessel has not yet completed its passage to the seated woman. Matejko holds attention around that anticipated exchange, with surrounding faces giving an ordinary act of offering its danger. The subject depends on unequal knowledge. What can look like service within a furnished room becomes threatening when the historical title changes how the approach is read.

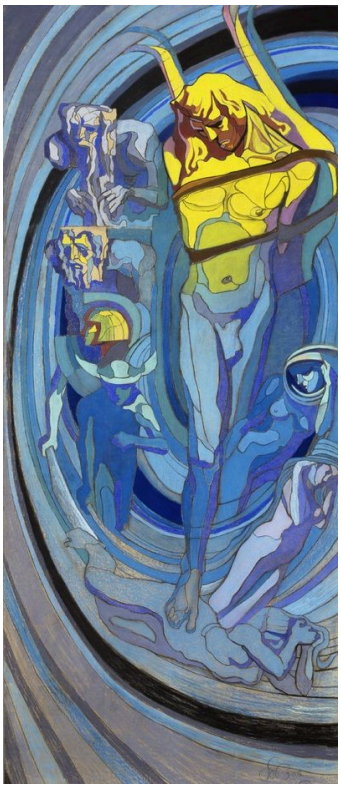
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-a-1321

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Apollo: Copernicus's Solar System

Stanisław Wyspiański

1904 · Pastel on cardboard · National Museum in Kraków



Stanisław Wyspiański. Apollo - Copernicus' Solar System. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/stanislaw-wyspianski/apollowys · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The central yellow body belongs to a network of curved blue bands and smaller forms. Wyspiański organises the figure for a window design, where boundaries must remain legible across divided areas. Astronomical order becomes a problem of visual arrangement. The body supplies a centre, while surrounding lines make that centre part of a larger, interlocking system.

Object source · Open artwork

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Motherhood

Stanisław Wyspiański

1905 · Pastel on cardboard · National Museum in Kraków



Stanisław Wyspiański. Motherhood. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/stanislaw-wyspianski/motherhood-1905 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Nursing gives the group a practical centre. The girls' inclined heads extend attention towards mother and infant, while patterned clothes and flowers remain active around them. Wyspiański lets ornament connect the figures without replacing what they are doing. Repeated curves join bodily care to the picture's surface, keeping the intimate task visible within the decorative density.

Object source · Open artwork

13 / 20

Self-Portrait with His Wife

Stanisław Wyspiański

1904 · Pastel on laid paper · National Museum in Kraków



Stanisław Wyspiański; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The couple face out together, but their expressions and clothing do not merge. Red beads and the headscarf define one figure; shoulder-to-shoulder placement supplies the shared arrangement. Wyspiański makes partnership visible through closeness while preserving differences. The portrait offers a constructed image of being together, not evidence that two people possess a single temperament.

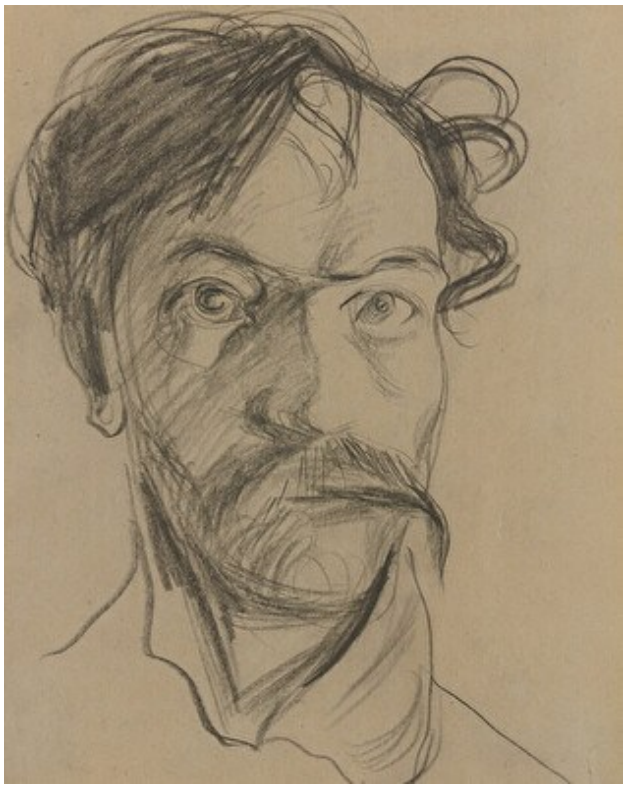
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK III-r.a-10895

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Self-Portrait a Month before Death

Stanisław Wyspiański

1907 · Crayon drawing on paper · National Museum in Kraków



Stanisław Wyspiański; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The title supplies a biographical horizon that can overwhelm the drawing if it is allowed to explain every line. Wyspiański concentrates the darkest marks around eyes, mouth and loose hair, leaving the sheet comparatively open elsewhere. The face remains insistently particular. Its economy records a bodily presence without inventing the final thoughts that the work cannot disclose.

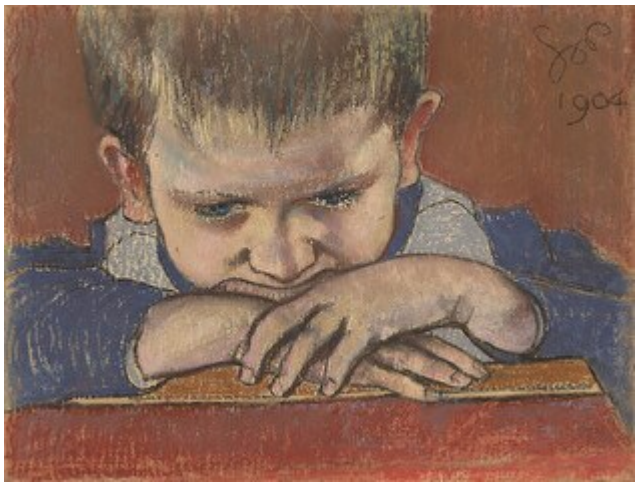
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK III-r.a-4780

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Mietek Leaning on His Arms

Stanisław Wyspiański

1904 · Pastel on paper · National Museum in Kraków



Stanisław Wyspiański; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The chin rests above folded hands, making the child's weight part of the likeness. His lowered brow changes the space around the eyes without requiring a theatrical expression. Wyspiański gives an unceremonious posture the attention of a portrait. The supporting arms explain how the face is held, grounding an encounter that could otherwise become only a study of features.

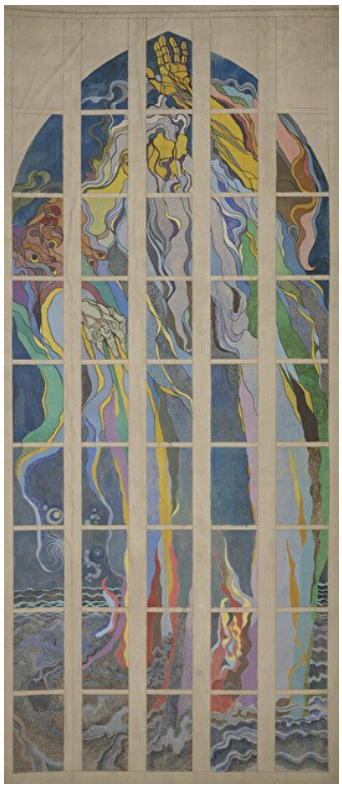
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK III-r.a-10757

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God the Father: Replica of a Window Design

Stanisław Wyspiański

1904 · Pastel and tempera on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Stanisław Wyspiański; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The tall robed figure extends through an arched field whose pale divisions remain visible. Blue and yellow forms cross those boundaries with sweeping movement. The museum object is a replica of a design, not the installed window itself. Its arrangement nonetheless makes clear how a figure can be conceived in relation to a long, structurally divided surface.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-b-514

17 / 20

Self-Portrait with a Palette

Anna Bilińska

1887 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Anna Bilińska-Bohdanowicz; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

Bilińska's painting equipment and pale apron identify an artist through the practical circumstances of work. Her direct face remains composed above the occupied lap. The restrained setting avoids competing claims on attention. Professional presence is established through a usable arrangement of body and tools, rather than through the addition of a grand studio backdrop.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-a-211

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Self-Portrait in White

Jacek Malczewski

1914 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Jacek Malczewski; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The elaborate white costume and hat make Malczewski's appearance conspicuously selected. Hands at the waist reinforce a frontal presentation, while red accents punctuate the pale clothing. This is self-portraiture as the adoption of a visible role. The unusual outfit should prompt attention to how the artist presents himself, not an assumption that the image is an unguarded glimpse.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-b-1762

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The Death of Ellenai

Jacek Malczewski

1883 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Jacek Malczewski; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

Heavy fabrics enclose the pale horizontal body, while the seated man retains an upright presence beside it. Malczewski translates a literary death into a relationship of weight, position and stillness. The survivor cannot share the body's condition even though he occupies the same close room. That physical separation carries the scene more precisely than a general declaration of grief would.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-b-1

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The Red Parasol

Józef Mehoffer

1917 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Kraków



Józef Mehoffer; National Museum in Kraków; Muzeum Narodowe w Krakowie. Domena publiczna (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · Domena publiczna

The parasol gives a small seated figure a concentrated presence within the extensive garden. Mehoffer allows paths, beds and dense trees to retain their own structure, so the woman does not become the setting's sole purpose. Bright red establishes a point of rest within cultivated abundance. Leisure is given a location rather than simply an attractive backdrop.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MNK II-b-3845

One museum, several settings

The National Museum in Kraków comprises different branches; this selection is not a route through a single building. Check each work's current location and access information. A useful comparison to carry between them is the hand: supporting, restraining, working or commanding, it can change the scale at which a subject becomes understandable.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s notebooks discuss painting through observation of movement, light and the body. They offer a starting point for the first portrait, and a productive comparison with the more emphatic outlines in Wyspiański’s work.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12